

Philosophy of Science
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Lecture 11

Absolutism and Relativism

Motivation of this lecture

- International studies often involves making sense of...
 - Claims from differing perspectives
 - Radically divergent reasoning styles
 - Different cultures
- Concepts of absolutism and relativism
 - Useful tools for analysing and discussing our attitudes to such diversity

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Plan of this lecture

- What are absolutism and relativism?
 - Claims about how entities possess a certain property
 - Absolutism and relativism about property F
- Focus on epistemological properties
 - F = truth, rationality
 - Applications to history of science and cultural anthropology

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Reading for this lecture

- Maria Baghramian, "The Virtues of Relativism"
 - *Aristotelian Society Supplementary Volume* 93 (2019), pp. 247–269
- Available on Brightspace

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Reminder—next week

- Our final meeting
 - Wednesday 20 May 2026
 - Course review, exam preparation, question period
- Please prepare by...
 - reviewing the course material and your notes
 - formulating any outstanding questions

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Relativism in public discourse

- Some participants in public debates associate relativism with...
 - Lack of standards
 - An “anything goes” attitude
 - Postmodernism
- Such global dismissals of relativism are misguided
 - Instead, we focus on precise content of claims

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Absolutism and relativism

- Absolutism about property F is the thesis that...
 - entities have or lack F intrinsically
 - perspective plays no part in determining whether an entity has F
- Relativism about F is the thesis that...
 - it is not the case that entities have or lack F intrinsically
 - entities have or lack F only relative to a perspective S

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Relativism: simple example

- Identify F with utility or usefulness
- Relativism about utility is the thesis that...
 - it is not the case that entities have or lack utility intrinsically
 - entities have or lack utility only relative to S
 - S here ranges over aims or purposes
- Question: is a tin-opener useful?
 - Sole sensible reply: it depends on your aims

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Implications of this account

- Absolutism/relativism is a set of views
 - Only absolutism/relativism about property F is a specific view—a view about how F is correctly attributed
- If relativism about F holds, then F is...
 - a two-place relation between the entity and S
 - not a one-place predicate
- Further examples of S :
 - Standpoints, cultures, world views, styles, conceptual schemes, practices, disciplines

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Next task

- We now explore absolutism and relativism about two epistemological properties
 - Truth
 - Rationality
- That is, we shall fill in first “truth” and then “rationality” for variable F

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Truth: preliminaries

- Truth is a property only of propositions
 - Not of facts, arguments, or any other thing—recall lecture 2
 - So absolutism and relativism about truth are views of how propositions possess the property “truth”
- “Truth value” means “truth or falsity”
 - “Truth value of proposition P ” means “ P ’s being true or false”

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Application to truth

- Absolutism about truth
 - A proposition’s truth value is an intrinsic property of it, given how the world is
 - Whether a proposition is true or false does not depend on perspective
- Relativism about truth
 - A proposition’s truth value depends on perspective
 - We need to take perspective into account when assessing the truth of propositions

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Absolutism about truth

- . An absolutist about truth believes that...
 - . in a controversy where participants disagree about the truth value of various claims...
 - . each of these claims is either true or false for all participants...
 - . even though, during the controversy, we may not know which claims are true and which false

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Relativism about truth

- . A relativist about truth believes that...
 - . A proposition can be true from my perspective and false from your perspective
- . Caution: sentences with indexical terms
 - . Examples of indexical: *I, this, here, now...*
 - . "I teach philosophy of science" may seem true if I utter it and false if you utter it...
 - . But the two utterances make distinct claims!

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Relativism about truth: appraisal

- . Consensus in analytic philosophy
 - . Unrestricted relativism about truth is self-subverting
 - . Hence, the stance is incoherent
- . Refutation of relativism about truth
 - . Hinges on self-reference, or a proposition's referring to itself

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Refuting relativism about truth

- . First, state relativism about truth:
 - . "Assertion *P* has or lacks truth not absolutely, but only relative to perspective"
- . Then, apply this claim to itself
 - . That is, replace *P* in the above statement with the claim of relativism about truth
- . Thus, we cannot assert relativism about truth regardless of perspective

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Relativism about truth: verdict

- Conclusion: relativism about truth cannot be maintained consistently
 - It entails that its own statement is not absolutely valid
- Example of propositions that undermine themselves through self-reference, like:
 - "The penultimate sentence on sheet 17 is not true"
 - "For every generalisation, there is an exception"

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Possible defences

- Defence 1: relativism by stipulation
 - Introduce a new property, "subjective truth"
 - Response: subjective truth is a property different from truth
- Defence 2: avert self-reference
 - Introduce a metalanguage
 - Allocate statement of relativism about truth to different level from other statements
 - Response: requires a piecemeal theory of truth

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Implications

- We need to acknowledge alternative perspectives on the way things are
 - But adopting relativism about truth is not a good way of doing this
- Better ways:
 - Reconstruct claims more fully, to show that different people are putting forward different claims
 - Acknowledge genuine justifications for untrue claims
 - Consider relativism about rationality

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From truth to rationality

- We shall now formulate and evaluate...
 - absolutism and relativism about rationality
- Rationality: a property of an action
 - Recall lecture 9
- Here: a property of a reasoning style
 - Does a reasoning style have or lack rationality (i.e., is it or is it not rational) absolutely...
 - or only relative to perspective?

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Absolutism about rationality 1

- There are many reasoning styles
 - Used by different people in different contexts
- Each reasoning style has or lacks rationality intrinsically
 - Does not depend on perspective
- Usual implied addition
 - Only one reasoning style has rationality
 - All other reasoning styles lack it

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Absolutism about rationality 2

- Typical motivation for absolutism about rationality
 - To be rational is to reason in accord with the world
 - A reasoning style intrinsically either is or is not in accord with the world
 - Furthermore, since the world is unique, only one reasoning style is rational

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Absolutism about rationality 3

- Absolutism about rationality...
 - fosters a judgemental stance towards different reasoning styles
- My reasoning style, *R*, is rational
 - Any reasoning style that deviates from *R* is irrational
 - No appeal to perspective can amend this verdict
- Often claimed on behalf of Western logic and science

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Relativism about rationality 1

- Relativism about rationality says...
 - a reasoning style has or lacks rationality only relative to perspective
 - Perspective: conceptual or cultural setting
 - Different reasoning styles are on a par in their own settings
- Implication: non-uniqueness claim
 - No single reasoning style has a privileged relation with reality

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Relativism about rationality 2

- Typical motivation for relativism about rationality: empirical evidence of...
 - plurality of reasoning styles
 - their effectiveness in their own settings
- Diversity in time and in place
 - History of science—Kuhn's view
 - Cultural anthropology—oscillation between extreme absolutism and extreme relativism

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History of science—Kuhn's view

- Revolutions bring shifts in rationality
 - Each paradigm has its own incommensurable form of rationality
 - Each is effective within its own paradigm
- No grounds for ranking reasoning styles
 - Is quantum reasoning better than Newtonian reasoning? Difficult to establish
- Early Kuhn as relativist about rationality
 - See lecture 6

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Cultural anthropology

- Can anthropologists assess other cultures' belief systems...
 - without imposing their own rational standards?
 - Or is rationality itself culture-bound?
- Tension in anthropology between...
 - universalist and relativist approaches to human reason

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Azande: introduction

- Agricultural people, northern Central Africa
 - Consult oracles, believe in witchcraft, and practise magic
 - Singular: "Zande"; plural: "Azande"
- Classical Western anthropology...
 - regarded Azande reasoning style as "irrational" and "primitive"
 - Extreme absolutism about rationality

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Azande and anthropology 1

- E. E. Evans-Pritchard (1902–1973)
 - British anthropologist: *Oracles, Witchcraft, and Magic Among the Azande* (1937)
- More nuanced absolutism
 - Azande's reasoning style (e.g. appealing to witchcraft) genuinely helps them make sense of misfortunes
 - However, Western frameworks show that it is flawed—witchcraft does not exist

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Azande and anthropology 2

- Peter Winch (1926–1997)
 - British philosopher of social science: "Understanding a Primitive Society" (1964)
- Appeal to forms of life
 - Accepting or rejecting appeals to witchcraft are the result of different forms of life
 - The Azande reasoning style is no less objective than ours

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Winch continued

- Winch's conclusions
 - Anthropologists are unable to ascertain that any culture is "wrong" in any respect about the world
 - Questioned the existence of objective cross-cultural standards of rationality
 - Far-reaching relativism about rationality

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Azande and anthropology 3

- Steven Lukes (1941–)
 - British social theorist: "Different Cultures, Different Rationalities?" (2000)
- Intermediate position
 - Our attempts to get the Azande right must respect their attempts to get the world right
 - But assessing rationality in other cultures is both possible and necessary
 - Existence of universal norms

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Recapitulation

- My advice: discuss absolutism and relativism...
 - only about some specified property F
 - not in general—that is not illuminating
- Relativism about truth
 - Not viable
- Relativism about rationality
 - Offers a non-judgemental way of accounting for different reasoning styles